

U.S. HISTORY HACK™ · TEACHER GUIDE

Teacher Guide & Answer Key

US.01 Homestead Act Document-Based Investigation

Implementation · source notes · model response ·
scoring · differentiation for 3 inclusion & 2 honors
sections

First-DBQ ready — everything you need to run it tomorrow.

Author-generated teacher materials (not externally graded) · public-domain sources · TroopToTeacher
Technologies LLC
Generated: 2026-08-11T01:51:23Z

1 · At a Glance

Field	Detail
Standard	US.01 — Homestead Act & Transcontinental Railroad → settlement of the West
Investigation question	Who gained a homestead — and who lost a homeland?
Documents	6 total: 2 verbatim statute-text (HIPPO) + 4 visual-primary (OPTIC)
Time	1-2 class periods (first DBQ — plan for 2). Day 1: docs A-F + sourcing. Day 2: plan + write.
Files	Student Workbook · Scaffold & Language-Access Companion · this Teacher Guide

Because this is students' first DBQ, teach the process explicitly. Model HIPPO on Document A and OPTIC on Document C with the whole class before releasing them to work. The scaffolds in the workbook fade by design (A-B full → C-E reduced → F independent); do not restore earlier scaffolds on later documents — the fade is the skill.

2 · Suggested Pacing

Time	Phase	What students do
10 min	Hook + frame	Read the investigation question; unpack “What is a DBQ?” page together.
15 min	Model	Teacher thinks aloud: HIPPO on Doc A, OPTIC on Doc C. Students fill along.
30 min	Guided → independent	Students work Docs B, D, E with reduced cues; Doc F independently.
15 min	Tennessee Connection	Discuss, then students write two reasoning sentences.
20 min	Plan + write	Complete the organizer, then draft the CER argument.
10 min	Self-score	Students score their draft on the rubric (and enter the thesis in the app if used).

3 · Source Notes (provenance + what to draw out)

Doc	Title & citation	Teaching move
-----	------------------	---------------

Doc A	The Homestead Act of 1862 — Who Could Claim the Land Homestead Act of 1862, 12 Stat. 392 (37th Cong., Sess. II, ch. 75); approved May 20, 1862. General Records of the U.S. Government, RG 11, U.S. National Archives. Verbatim transcription: National Archives & State Historical Society of North Dakota. Public domain (U.S. statute).	Establishes the promise in law. Point students to ‘unappropriated’ — the loaded assumption that Western land was free to give.
Doc B	The Homestead Act of 1862 — Prove It Up, or Lose It Homestead Act of 1862, 12 Stat. 392 (37th Cong., Sess. II, ch. 75); approved May 20, 1862. General Records of the U.S. Government, RG 11, U.S. National Archives. Verbatim transcription: National Archives & State Historical Society of North Dakota. Public domain (U.S. statute).	The five-year residence + ‘prove up’ terms. Ask who could afford five years before a harvest; connect to commutation (\$1.25/acre) as a wealth advantage.
Doc C	Driving the Last Spike, Promontory Summit, 1869 Russell, Andrew J. East and West Shaking Hands at the Laying of the Last Rail, Promontory Summit, Utah Territory, May 10, 1869. Public domain. (Held: Yale Collection of Western Americana.)	Sourcing lens: a posed press photo of a national triumph. Ask who is absent — Chinese and Irish labor, and displaced nations.
Doc D	Railroad Systems of the United States, 1890 Railroad Systems of the United States: 1890 (Plate 60). Henry Gannett / U.S. Census Office, Statistical Atlas of the United States. Library of Congress, Geography & Map Division. Public domain.	Geographic reasoning (SSP.06). Have students trace how western lines cut through Native homelands to reach homestead country.
Doc E	A Homestead Family ‘Proved Up,’ Custer County, Nebraska, 1886 Butcher, Solomon D. Sod house of the Sylvester Rawding family, north of Sargent, Custer County, Nebraska. 1886. Nebraska State Historical Society, Solomon D. Butcher Collection. (Copy: Library of Congress, LC-USZ62-8276.) Public domain.	The promise realized for one family. Butcher sold these images as proof of success — a purpose that makes the photo a mild argument.
Doc F	Tom Torlino, Navajo — Carlisle Indian School, 1882 & 1885 Choate, John N. Tom Torlino, Navajo — on arrival (1882) and after about three years (1885) at the Carlisle Indian Industrial School, Pennsylvania. Carlisle Indian School Digital Resource Center / Richard Henry Pratt Papers, Beinecke Library, Yale University. Public domain.	The cost. Handle with care and dignity; this is documented history of forced assimilation. Students reason from the pairing's intent, not a handed-down verdict.

All sources public domain with citable archives. Statute text is a verbatim excerpt of the Homestead Act of 1862 (12 Stat. 392); the workbook's Plain-Language boxes are paraphrase aids clearly labeled as such, never presented as the primary source.

4 • Model Thesis & Annotated Exemplar

Model thesis (target, level 3-4): “The Homestead Act gave 160 acres and a real chance at ownership to settlers and immigrants who could survive five years on the land (Docs A, B, E), but it treated Native homeland as ‘unappropriated’ and helped push nations off their land (Docs D, F); therefore the Act was progress for some Americans and dispossession for others.”

Annotated exemplar paragraph (teacher reference — how the parts earn rubric points):

[Claim] The Homestead Act's benefits and costs fell on different people. **[Evidence + sourcing]** The law itself promised any adult citizen 160 acres for a \$10 filing fee and five years' work (Doc A) — and the Rawding family photo (Doc E), which a photographer sold as proof of success, shows a family who made it. **[Reasoning]** For them the promise was real. **[Counter-evidence]** But the same law called the land “unappropriated,” and the before-and-after photos of Tom Torlino (Doc F) record Native children forced to shed their culture as their homelands were opened. **[Reasoning]** So “free land” for settlers was lost land for Native nations.

Use this to calibrate scoring — do not distribute it before students draft.

5 • Scoring Rubric (AP-aligned, 20 pts)

Criterion	4 — Exceeds	3 — Meets	2 — Approaching	1 — Beginning
Thesis (Claim)	Defensible claim answering “for whom?” with nuance	Clear claim that takes a position	Claim restates the prompt	No clear claim
Evidence — documents	≥4 documents used accurately	3 documents used accurately	2 documents	0-1 documents
Sourcing (HIPPO/OPTIC)	Sources ≥2 docs (POV/ purpose)	Sources 1 doc	Attempts sourcing	No sourcing
Analysis — gain & cost	Weights gain and cost with reasoning	Names a gain and a cost	One-sided	Summary only
Tennessee Connection	Uses a TN example as evidence	Mentions a TN example	Vague TN reference	None

20 points total (5 criteria × 4). Meets = 15/20. Convert to your gradebook as needed.

6 • Differentiation Plan — 3 Inclusion Sections & 2 Honors Sections

Group	What to hand them	What success looks like
-------	-------------------	-------------------------

3 Inclusion sections ★ Entry	Workbook + the Scaffold & Language-Access Companion . Read the Plain-Language boxes aloud (or use the app read-aloud). Pre-teach the word bank. Do Docs A & C together; allow partners for D-E; Doc F optional. Sentence stems available for the whole write.	A claim + at least 2 documents + one sourced document, using the stems. Full HIPPO/OPTIC frames may stay in use throughout.
2 Honors sections ▲ Extension	Workbook only (no companion). Assign the ▲ Honors extension question under each document and the historiography prompt below. Push independent sourcing from Doc B onward.	A nuanced “for whom” thesis + ≥4 documents + ≥2 sourced + a weighed counterargument + the Tennessee Connection as real evidence.

▲ **Honors historiography prompt:** “Historians disagree about whether the Homestead Act is best understood as a democratic land reform that built the American middle class, or as an engine of Native dispossession. Stake a position and defend it using at least four documents plus one piece of outside evidence.”

Accommodations note. These supports work **alongside — never in place of** — a student's legally required IEP/504 accommodations. Common built-ins available here: read-aloud (app), EN/ES word bank, sentence stems, chunked documents, partner work, extended time, and reduced document load (minimum 2 docs to meet the standard).

7 • Honest Disclosure

These teacher materials — model thesis, annotated exemplar, and rubric — are **author-generated by TroopToTeacher Technologies LLC** and have not been externally graded or normed. They are provided to calibrate scoring, not as an official answer key. The five documents are public domain; the statute text is verbatim from the Homestead Act of 1862 (12 Stat. 392, approved May 20, 1862).

Framework stack: TN US.01 first → RH/WHST literacy (cross-subject proof only; not marketed as Common Core per T.C.A. §49-6-2202) → AP U.S. History → C3 → IDM. History Hack is a **supplemental** resource under T.C.A. §49-6-2202(a)(3).

Trademarks use ™. ISBN [to be assigned]. Generated 2026-08-11T01:51:23Z.